

Photo: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

DETERRENCE TO DOMINANCE

The Bamuni, Kishanganj and Chopra bases give India an edge in the corridor



kan military station at Bamuni near Dhubri, Assam—the first permanent army base along Assam's border with Bangladesh. Spread across 65 acres and operating under the Tezpur-based 4 Corps (Gajraj Corps), it is designed for rapid deployment, counter-infiltration and area domination. It hosts 1,500 personnel, including a para special forces detachment. Two additional forward garrisons in Kishanganj, Bihar, and Chopra, North Bengal, have been rapidly developed at the edge of the corridor. Situated less than a kilometre from Tetulia in Bangladesh, the Chopra base occupies a tactical location. Both garrisons house around 1,000 troops and are under the 17 Mountain Strike Corps (Brahmastra Corps) based in Panagarh, Bengal. Complementing the new bases is the new Logistic Unit HQ 111 Area—responsible for faster logistics and operational coordination—at the Bengdubi Military Station in Siliguri subdivision.

Given its vital importance, the Siliguri Corridor is well served militarily—the area falls under the command of the Trishakti Corps (*33* Corps) based in Sukna near Siliguri, which has assets like T-90 battle tanks, mechanised infantry, S-400 air defence systems and Akash missiles and BrahMos missile systems across its component units in Gangtok, and Binnaguri and Kalimpong in Bengal and Rafale fighter jets at the Hashimara airbase in Bengal. However, the initial response to hostile action is the responsibility of the BSF. The addition of the three forward bases suggests a gear up from deterrence to dominance. Military officials say the result is a sweeping transformation of the corridor's combat readiness: armoured columns, drones and quick-reaction forces can now reach any point of the corridor within minutes rather than hours.

Lt Gen. Vinod Bhatia, former *33* Corps commander, says it is high time India strengthened its defences. "New garrisons are essential to enhance military capabilities and maintain combat readiness, as movement in the mountains is slow," he says. Overall, New Delhi's concerns reflect the rapid realignment of Bangladesh's foreign and security policy. Under the interim government headed by Mohammed Yunus, anti-India sentiments have swept the country and ties with Pakistan have warmed at an unprecedented speed. A few months ago, Indian Army chief Gen. Upendra Dwivedi publicly stated that he was concerned about the presence of the Pakistan army and Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) agents near the Chicken's Neck.

A TURN IN BANGLADESH

Soon after Yunus took over, Bangladesh flipped its security outlook, throwing itself fully into a China–Pakistan defence axis. The shift was felt on the ground—in March–April 2025, Bangladesh began reviving the World War II–era Lalmonirhat airbase in north Bangladesh, located just 16 km from the Siliguri Corridor. Announced first as a civilian upgrade, the project drew attention after visits by Chinese officials and reports that a Pakistani defence firm might be brought in for construction. Intelligence now confirms construction of a radar system and the installation of perimeter floodlights and advanced surveillance systems. The construction of a large hangar at nearby Haribhanga is nearly complete. Analysts expect it to house fighter jets and military drones. On October 16, Bangladesh Army chief Gen. Waker-uz-Zaman inspected both facilities. Their activation would enhance China/ Pakistan's ability to conduct aerial surveillance of Indian military installations.

This has not happened in a vacuum. Heavy Industries Taxila, a Pakistani military supplier, is upgrading Bangladeshi tanks; pilot courses are offered in anticipation of Bangladesh acquiring JF-17 fighter jets; in a first since 1971, a Pakistan Navy ship, *PNS Saif*, docked in Chattogram port in November; a Bangladesh Navy ship, *BNS Samudra Joy*, participated in Pakistan's AMAN-2025 naval exercise in February and ISI teams are operating in Bangladesh. High-level military visits are enablers—in January 2025, principal staff officer of the Armed Forces Division of Bangladesh, Lt Gen. S.M. Kamrul Hasan, met Pakistan Chief of Army Staff Gen. S.S. Mirza and Pakistan Air Force chief Air Chief Marshal Zaheer Ahmed Baber Sidhu in Pakistan. Mirza and Pakistan's director general of

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